Comte

Auguste Comte is one of the most important and influential, yet surprisingly, one of the least read of the great nineteenth-century philosophers. He is generally regarded as the founder of positivism, a scientistic and naturalistic tendency in Western thought, and he also invented or developed the discipline of sociology, and much of modern social theory is indebted both to his nomenclature and to his presuppositions about the world and about our access to knowledge of human actions and institutions. He receives little attention in contemporary great-books syllabi, partly because his writing is long, ponderous, involved and inaccessible. A second difficulty is his history of mental illness and the controversial character of his later work. He suffered a severe mental crisis in 1826, well before his final years.

His later writings have often been interpreted through the lens of that illness and have made him an easy target for parody, sometimes appearing almost self-parodic. His early work, however, is profound and brilliant. His influence on the philosophy and history of science and on modern Western social science is immensely important. This makes Comte worth taking from the library shelves and examining again. Basic ideas of modern social science are already formulated in his work. He lived in the early nineteenth century and died in 1857, roughly a contemporary of Marx. His effort to construct a logic of historical development invites comparison with Marx, Hegel and French utopian socialism.

He was connected with Saint-Simon and belonged to a broader movement to systematize the human sciences and recognize the effects of the industrial, scientific and technological revolutions on our conception of humanity and society. The triumph of modern natural science, from the Enlightenment to Comte, is irreversible. Its effects on our understanding of knowledge and ourselves must be assessed.

There are at least four important influences on Comte's thought. The first is Catholicism. He comes from an orthodox, royalist, Catholic family, extremely conservative and traditional. His education at the École polytechnique creates a polarization in his thought. On the one hand, he longs for the organic stability and unity characteristic of medieval Catholicism. Order and progress become the great watchwords of his political theory. He finds the stable order of feudal Europe attractive and longs for it. Comte was very much opposed to the Reformation, very much opposed to the French Revolution. He disliked disorder, and he was attempting to create the possibility for human progress without the convulsive disorder that we find, say, in the wars of religion or in the French Revolution. Catholicism and the order and structure that is entailed there is a big influence on his thinking.

The second big influence comes from his polytechnic education. Modern natural science is a fundamental concern for him. He was proficient in the scientific disciplines within his horizon. A gifted mathematician, he also knew contemporary physics, biology and chemistry: a polymathic intellect. Like Aristotle, he brings together the disciplines of his time, trying to synthesize and organize them. He also had a creative streak, and, unfortunately, a messianic streak that emerged late in his career. At least initially, his project is to synthesize and unify the sciences as they have developed since the age of,

say, Copernicus or Galileo. He seeks one intellectual structure that validates and connects them. Since his outlook treats nature as the whole of reality, logically organizing the natural sciences would organize all knowledge. There is a sense that he is the culmination of a certain kind of intellectual tradition.

Modern natural science and its relation to religious belief were a source of persistent tension for Comte. A third big influence is the French Revolution. Comte disliked revolutionary convulsions on the whole. He was a very conservative, almost reactionary political thinker, and the French Revolution is his example of what must be avoided in our future political progress. In other words, although he admires order, he wants to allow for the introduction of salutary changes, but he wants to make sure that these salutary changes are not accompanied with the tremendous misery that was connected with things like the wars of religion or with the terror of the French Revolution. The final great influence on Comte was the tradition of French utopian socialism, and in this respect, he responds to dissatisfaction with industrial society comparable to that of Marx or Charles Dickens.

Industrial society disrupted social and family life and created problems that traditional political theories had not formulated or addressed in their modern form. Aquinas, for example, offers no developed account of the problems of industrial child labor. The rise of science and industrial society generates new questions which Comte confronts. His solutions may be largely unsatisfactory, as with much utopian socialism, with emphasis on “utopian.” Yet raising these questions is a breakthrough. If his answers are not very satisfactory, the questions remain with us or minimally have to be reformulated because he's gesturing at the kind of problems we can't escape. They're a concomitant of the world we live in.

Comte never achieved the institutional success he wanted. He remained an intellectual outsider and experienced serious psychological difficulties, including depression and a tendency toward grandiosity. His exceptional mathematical and intellectual gifts, and his ambition to unify the sciences, easily acquired a messianic character, particularly late in his career. The project is a monument to intellectual hubris, Platonic in its aspirations more than its achievements. After unifying physical, moral and political knowledge under one method and demonstrating all its connections, what remains to be done? The rest of intellectual life would be an anticlimax. Comte believes that he achieves this early in life, reinforcing his grandiosity and making the problem worse. Separating genuine intellectual achievements from the elements critics regard as pathological is difficult. This helps explain his neglect despite his importance. He never obtained a regular university professorship; his intellectual independence, political views and personal difficulties complicated his career. He lectured in his own apartment.

His lectures resembled a small intellectual salon. His course began in 1826, was interrupted by his mental crisis and resumed in 1829. His difficulties included profound depression and a suicide attempt. The audience nevertheless included distinguished thinkers: the mathematician and physicist Joseph Fourier, not the utopian socialist Charles Fourier, and the German naturalist Alexander von Humboldt. John Stuart Mill, although he did not attend these lectures, was deeply impressed by Comte's achievements. Important thinkers acknowledge his ambitions even when they reject his

solutions. His extraordinary gifts coexist with psychological illness, and his increasingly extravagant ambitions make him vulnerable to ridicule.

Comte's direct following in France was limited, although his ideas later influenced French intellectual life more widely. He also attracted scattered followers abroad, notably in Brazil, beyond the traditional centers of Western high culture. The saying that a prophet has little honor in his own country is relevant, with particular emphasis on the word prophet. The intellectuals who noticed his work were rightly impressed by its scope and ambition. His first major work was the six-volume *Course of Positive Philosophy*, published between 1830 and 1842.

The work reformulates his private lectures. Its six volumes cover the natural sciences, which he treats as the basis of all science and legitimate knowledge. Psychology is integrated into biological and social inquiry. He brings social science together in one new, overarching discipline, sociology. He views it as being something analogous to social physics. Comte undertakes a logical and historical analysis of the development of human knowledge, and he tries to fill in the keystone in the arch, finishing off that project of the development of human self-consciousness and of consciousness of the external world. Its two aspects are a philosophy of history and an epistemological position. The philosophy of history provides a useful starting point.

It proposes a necessary development through three stages, applying both to civilizations and to their intellectual components: the theological stage, the metaphysical stage and the final positive stage, which Comte sees as the stage of his own age. The elements of knowledge are mathematics, astronomy, physics, chemistry, biology, including physiology, and sociology. Psychology is not an independent introspective science in this classification; its legitimate study is connected with biology and social observation. Sociology completes the development: human beings acquire a scientific understanding of the society in which they participate. Six disciplines encompass legitimate scientific knowledge and form a unified whole. They study the same world of space and time, but not by identical procedures. Comte has not arrived at the more reductive tendencies associated with parts of twentieth-century positivism. Each discipline develops its own reasoning and methods. Sociology is therefore not simply reducible to physics, unlike the ambition toward physicalist unification later associated with some members of the Vienna Circle.

The sciences divide into natural kinds: logical differences correspond to differences in their objects. This may be a survival of scholasticism in Comte. Each of the individual disciplines has to go through these three phases, and all cultures must go through these phases as well. The first phase is the theological phase, and if you think about it, this is not at all an implausible set of ideas. In the most ancient strata of human history and of human society, knowledge is always bound up with myth. When the ancient sages studied astronomy, astronomy and astrology were the same discipline. They weren't separate. Calling a constellation “the Lion,” or Leo, probably connects it with a lion myth. Such early astronomy contains mystical and mythological elements.

Early physics is likewise expressed through mythology. A famous legend says that Pythagoras sacrificed an ox after discovering his theorem, a squared plus b squared equals c squared. The implication is that mathematical knowledge comes from the gods. There are grounds for believing that knowledge of the external world, and perhaps other

legitimate knowledge, passes through a theological or mythological phase. Nature is given anthropomorphic personality and intention. In ancient Greece, even a statue that fell on someone could be held responsible. That is a holdover from this magic thinking. It is an artifact of that primitive theological physics.

Comte argues that mathematics, astronomy, physics, chemistry, physiology and theories of society pass through an initial theological phase. His outlook is pre-Darwinian: he died in 1857, whereas *On the Origin of Species* appeared in 1859. He therefore lacks an element later naturalistic thinkers would draw from evolutionary theory: an account connecting organic development with natural processes without invoking a directing intelligence. This helps explain why he keeps the sciences of life and matter logically distinct. Without pressing the origins of humanity too far, cave paintings of bison can illustrate the early theological stage. Comte sees theological knowledge extending through Western culture into European feudalism and regards a comparable stage as common to other cultures. Science, mathematics and physiology are still discussed through theological categories. Comte says while this is a noble and necessary process, it has to be superseded because it just doesn't work, which is a very good reason to believe it. His influence on pragmatism is often ignored and is actually quite significant.

For Comte, what works counts. Within the theological stage are further subdivisions, inviting comparison with Vico's ages of gods, heroes and men, or with Hegel's triadic development. These subphases also appear to be necessary. The first phase is what he calls the fetishistic phase, in which you attribute to special rocks or special trees, if you think of the religion of the druids, special magical powers, the power to give you good weather or bad weather, things like that. He says that's the earliest and most primitive phase, fetishism. The second phase will be the transformation of fetishism into polytheism. The best example here would be Homer, and Comte's scheme would also place polytheistic aspects of Hinduism here. The third phase within this theological stage of development is monotheism, which is what he sees as being the great contribution of the Judeo-Christian tradition. It is the highest of the theological phases because it is the most unified, it is the most elegant, and it is the one that sets the preconditions for the movement into the next stage, which is the metaphysical stage.

For Comte, the metaphysical stage differs from the theological stage in that it accounts for the world around us, not with these anthropomorphic entities, the tree god and the stone god and the sky god. It accounts for these things using intellectual abstractions, like forces, causes, rights. For Comte, much thought between Plato and the French Revolution exemplifies metaphysics. Examples include Platonic Forms, scholastic essences and existences, Descartes' clear and distinct ideas, and Rousseau's natural rights. These are metaphysical abstractions. He wants to leave such abstractions behind and move on to the next necessary phase, which is the positive phase. The positive phase is the phase of society where we get rid of all these explanatory abstractions.

Positive inquiry abandons such abstractions as ultimate explanations. It does not need hidden forces, Platonic Forms or scholastic essences behind observable phenomena. It does, however, seek scientific laws describing regularities. It seeks knowledge in phenomena and their relations rather than in a second reality behind appearances. It essentially undoes the distinction between appearance and reality, which has been central to the Western tradition for at least twenty-three centuries. By undoing this distinction between appearance and reality, what Comte offers us is simple regularities,

mathematically expressed laws that tell you what goes on in the world. Repeated observation supports lawlike generalizations. Scientists combine these into compact, precise mathematical representations, such as $F = ma$. In principle, certainly physics is susceptible to that.

Astronomy and physics have passed through the stages. Physiology also develops, with discoveries such as Harvey's account of the circulation of the blood. What Comte believes he is doing is finishing off. He brings the earlier social theories of Aristotle, Plato, Aquinas and their successors to a new level. Earlier thinkers about society, politics, ethics and knowledge are either bound to theology or transitional intellectual "amphibians" at the metaphysical level. He presents himself as the first positivist sociologist, explaining human society without metaphysical abstractions. The sciences form a unity: because mathematics, physics and chemistry pass through the stages, sociology must necessarily do so too. The idea is intriguing and contains a substantial element of truth. Such categories can be fruitful for organizing world history, provided they are not pressed too far.

The difficulty is that, like Hegel, Comte erects what he regards as a final structure. In other words, all the previous historical and logical development of our species leads up to him. He is the uniquely omniscient self-consciousness of our species, which has finally liberated us from the bondage of metaphysics and theology. Finally, we are free. There is a deeply troubling messianic element to this. Hegel also has that tendency, but the fact that Hegel is a Lutheran makes him a little bit more restrained in the messianic tendencies of this. A musical analogy is the difference between Mozart's *Requiem* and Verdi's *Requiem*. Both concern final, eternal matters, but Mozart's treatment is more restrained. Mozart himself was Catholic, so this is a contrast of style rather than a literal contrast between Protestant and Catholic composers. Verdi's *Requiem*, composed after Comte's death, addresses the same ultimate matters in a vast and emotionally extravagant form. There is too much of everything. There is a loss of a sense of proportion here in Comte. The difference between Comte and Hegel is that it becomes very obvious in Comte, whereas Hegel finds ways of restraining these tendencies towards omniscience.

The three stages became influential, with modifications, in social and historical thought. William H. McNeill offers a useful comparison: a modern historian concerned with humanity's place in the natural world. If you get rid of Comte's disdain for non-Western cultures, which I think is one of the greatest flaws in his thinking, there is a sort of racism and a sort of Eurocentrism which is both unattractive and false. If you were to get rid of that and be a little more Catholic, a little more universal in your appreciation of the technological and sociological developments in non-Western cultures, I think that there is a considerable argument to make along these lines. All of the world's great cultures had a theological phase.

Some traditions, including the Greco-Roman and later scholastic traditions, also develop metaphysical ways of thinking. In this schema, the theological phase is followed by the metaphysical phase. The final phase, the positive phase, is caught up with the idea of the advance of modern natural science. If you notice how modern natural science has, at least within the elites across the world, become a sort of unifying ideology, the logical coherence of this becomes quite impressive and it turns out to be, with some caveats, a very useful set of intellectual categories. Comte and his theory of the development of the

human mind, while it has elements of grandiosity, certain elements which are very disturbing, there is a germ of truth here and it must be recognized.

It is worth extracting the sensible elements from the extravagant ones. Connected with this theory of historical development is, as in Hegel, an epistemology of the logical development of the sciences. Each of the sciences is connected by the fact that it refers to the same thing, the external world, reality, the world of space and time, and they have logical and historical relations to each other. You can't move astronomy from the theological to the metaphysical to the positive stage until mathematics does that first. Math has to come first. There's a definite logical hierarchy and historical hierarchy there. Once math starts to go through that process of development, then it's possible for astronomy to go through that development. Once astronomy starts to go through that development, then physics can start to go through that development, and then chemistry can start to go through that development, and then physiology can go through that development, and then we get Comte who's finishing the project.

The keystone goes into the arch, the progress of the human mind culminates with Comte in sociology. You can see how one is contingent upon the other, and there's a considerable amount of truth in that. This has been influential in the history of science. Greek advances in mathematics precede the much later development of quantum mechanics, which requires mathematical tools to be available first. It's not surprising that we don't develop a very sophisticated physiology until breakthroughs are made in physics and chemistry. Even amid the extravagance, there is intellectual resourcefulness. There is a profound brilliance here, and it is worth our while to think about the kind of way in which he's organizing this.

Like Aristotle, he unifies the knowledge of his age. Compared with Bacon's *The New Organon*, this can look like the real new organon, dwarfing Bacon's ambitions. He's a halfway point between someone like Lucretius, the Roman Epicurean, who's also a materialist, and Carnap, who goes for the real hard-shell positivism. He's the connecting link between the naturalistic, atomistic tendencies of the ancients and the modern tendency to derive all real knowledge from a scientific basis that we see in things like the Vienna Circle and the early Wittgenstein. His early work is two things. It's a philosophy of history, and at the same time it's an epistemology, and these things tend to merge.

Within concrete historical events, the logic and the necessary historical development manifest themselves. You can see resonances of Hegel here. This is the part of positivism which most contemporary positivists, most contemporary naturalistic thinkers like in Comte. Some followers wanted his later work excluded and his philosophy effectively bowdlerized. They regarded the writings after the *Course of Positive Philosophy* as inferior and as a departure from his earlier approach to nature and knowledge, interpreting them as evidence of mental decline. One reading therefore emphasizes the scientific side and treats it as an intellectual ancestor of Carnap, Schlick and Neurath. It confines Comtean positivism to the earlier work. Comte himself did not accept that separation. Other followers were attracted by the prospect of reconciling moral and political order with modern science. They emphasized the legitimacy of his later work, particularly the *System of Positive Polity*, published between 1851 and 1854. Comte insisted that the philosophy could not be separated from the polity. His project is

a theory of history and knowledge, but also a normative theory of how societies should be governed and improved.

He lives in the shadow of the French Revolution and is terrified by the revolutions of 1848 and what he wants to do is impose an old-fashioned backward-looking organic order on this very dynamic society. In this respect, he is reactionary, nostalgic for an earlier organic social unity. He argues that human development advances not just reasoning but sentiments: intellectual progress is accompanied by moral progress. The law of love has been expanded and universalized. Christianity, which he acknowledges, is an early primitive development, a mythological formulation of the true law of love which he somehow believes can be derived from his political and epistemological stance. Modern positivists reasonably doubt that normative claims can be derived from a purely naturalistic world. Comte evades Hume's distinction between is and ought by constructing a kind of cult of reason. Even though he would be loath to admit it, Comte is very much indebted to the cult of reason that comes from the Jacobins of the French Revolution and he makes a sort of hybrid between the Jacobin cult of reason and the civil religion that Rousseau introduces at the end of the famous book, *The Social Contract*.

Rousseau's work ends with a simple civil religion. Many French thinkers seem unable to imagine society without religion, perhaps because of Catholicism's influence on the French intellectual tradition. It's hard for them to imagine a stable polity that doesn't have some sort of religious foundation. Even a guy as skeptical and as revolutionary in some ways as Rousseau can't imagine it. Comte picks up on that tendency. Comte calls his new foundation the Religion of Humanity. Here the project becomes particularly vulnerable to ridicule and to the charge that its author's ambitions have lost all proportion.

The first thing Comte does is construct this new Ersatz Catholicism by leaving out essentially the Jesus stories and by introducing his own conception of right and wrong, which he somehow takes to be canonical and authoritative. In other words, to call him the new Pope of this new religion doesn't quite do him justice. He's more like the new Messiah of this new religion. He appoints himself to both roles and signs letters “High Priest of the Religion of Humanity.” This title made correspondence uneasy for admirers such as John Stuart Mill, who regarded the later development as a melancholy decline of a great intellect. With no God or metaphysical realm in his system, Comte seems to assume the role of ultimate authority himself.

He's the self-consciousness of our species and his religion of humanity is humanity worshiping itself. In other words, each individual, one of us, as a sort of cell in this eternal species being, in other words, it takes up Marxist and Hegelian resonances, saying that our real existence is not the individual body that we are but rather our existence as a species which goes on forever. He says, I'll give you a new ersatz alternative to the Christian offer of immortality.

Do good while you're here on earth, be virtuous, and you will live on forever in the memory of those who love you. There is, crazy as this seems, there's an element of truth in this. In other words, it's hard to separate the crazy stuff from the almost pedestrian observation that, well, if you do want any kind of immortality and you don't believe in a second world and in a heaven, the closest you're going to come is immortality in speech,

immortality in collective memory. The more troubling step is his claim to legislate how secular immortality will be achieved and who will deserve it. He reorganizes the calendar, replacing saints' days with celebrations of philosophers, scientists and literary figures. There is, for example, a month of Moses, honoring him as a great figure in human history. The Romans named months after Julius Caesar and Augustus, giving us July and August. Comte substitutes names of great contributors to humanity, including Moses, Descartes and the physiologist Bichat.

They'll be, of course, in a natural progressive order because the month will be a microcosm of all of historical time. In addition, different feasts will be celebrated in honor of particular problems that we have and there'll be a ritual associated with this. Ceremonies will celebrate the memory of these great figures. There will be a certain set of books which will be canonical for all positive thought. Of course, the last of these books that we really need to read is Comte's own work because he's finishing all this off. There is a combination of great insight and delusions of grandeur. He elects himself Pope to a religion he starts and expects the world, he literally expects positivism to supersede monotheism. In some ways there's a kind of crazy Promethean, almost Nietzschean will to take everything to its maximum extreme, except that the insanity of it becomes so much more visible. He's totally unselfconscious about seeming crazy because he's completely convinced that he has the final right answer.

Of course there are things that he doesn't consider. How do we know that the positive stage is the last one? If it's an inductive empirical activity, who knows what's going to come tomorrow? Think of the problems that are built into induction. How do you know it's going to be the end? He feels called and chosen, that's all you can say. The problem is not seriously confronted. Two readings of Comte are possible, one charitable and one severe.

The charitable reading sees a fundamentally humane person. The Religion of Humanity teaches injunctions such as “Love your neighbor” and “Live for others.” This suggests a kind-hearted man. He doesn't seem to me malicious. He does seem to me to have lost a sense of his own proportion, but that is perhaps a tragic result of making a Faustian bargain. Those people in the Western tradition, who are really under the misapprehension that they have the capacity to unify all of knowledge and to account for all previous logical and historical developments as leading up to them, have made a pact with the devil one way or another. The belief is mad, yet the attempt is noble and heroic in a Greek sense: full of hubris and intellectual pride, but also tragic nobility.

He is trying to do more than anyone could possibly do. He has constructed a cold and austere and harsh Cartesian universe, and at the same time he longs for a sort of Pascalian moral order, and the problem is the human mind just isn't big enough to do that. Even a huge mind like his can't do the job. So you see him in a kind of tug-of-war between his desire for moral order and his desire for logical clarity, and the problem is he pulls so hard in this tug-of-war that the rope snaps. Alas, we have here a tragic Faustian figure, who might have been a great man intellectually, but never realized his tremendous intellectual potentials because of this unfortunate lapse into madness.

The severe reading instead sees psychological disturbance and grandiosity from the beginning. His early career already exhibits suspicion and bitter personal conflict. His first intellectual mentor after he leaves the Polytechnic Institute is Saint-Simon, one of

the great French utopian socialists, and after a long and close connection in which they express considerable admiration for each other, they engage in mutual accusation of stealing each other's ideas. Comte accuses Saint-Simon, his mentor and employer. Saint-Simon accuses Comte, and they break permanently. Their thinking has obvious similarities. Saint-Simon proposed a Council of Newton, twenty-one leading scientists, writers and artists. Comte offers something comparable.

During the revolutions of 1848, he's terrified by the prospect of new political disorder in Europe. He says, now that I've thought about it, perhaps we should have the entire world ruled by what I will call the Positivist Council, and you can imagine who's going to preside over this council. Comte. As if reluctantly accepting a public nomination, he offers to preside because the world needs him. This is grandiosity: he expects others to be sufficiently knowledgeable, reasonable and receptive to beneficial change to recognize that the revolutions of 1848 are mistaken. What they really need is to be run by the smartest guy around. There's a sort of platonic element here. I would say that Comte is reacting to the new physics in the same way that Plato is reacting to the physics of the Milesians and trying to arrest the centrifugal tendencies that come out of that.

For Plato, religion was more integrated into the ordinary intellectual life of high culture, so this project was easier to formulate. By the early nineteenth century, reviving traditional religious order while making it logically satisfactory to modern science is, on this reading, already too late. Plato belonged to an age in which such a synthesis still seemed possible. Comte attempts what no one could accomplish. There is a certain heroic nobility in it, something reminiscent of Sisyphus, though that comparison may be harsh. He tries to do more than a human being can. The project is heroic in the Greek sense, but saturated with intellectual hubris, even more than Faust's. The harsh reading sees a man whose grandiosity was present from the outset, who elected himself not merely pope but messiah of a private religion. Followers reinforcing his convictions do not make them sounder. This helps explain why contemporary social scientists often neglect a thinker to whom they owe more than they realize. His work deserves a place in great-books curricula because it has been so influential.

Several modern influences show its importance. The problem of unifying the sciences around a common method and a common object, nature, remains central to the philosophy of science. The Vienna Circle's ideal of unified science and the work of Mach and Avenarius at the end of the nineteenth century belong to this broad trajectory. He also strongly influenced pragmatism through an essentially pragmatic standard of knowledge. Does it work? Then it's real positivistic knowledge. Don't give me any metaphysical element, just tell me if it works or not. He's also quite influential on Herbert Spencer and the development of things like social Darwinism. This hard-headed attempt to describe society as it actually is, independent of any metaphysical abstractions, is not so far from the early position that Comte takes.

Alongside methodological unity, the elimination of metaphysics recurs. A. J. Ayer's *Language, Truth and Logic* is a great positivist manifesto. What does he do in the first chapter? The elimination of metaphysics. Comte had done that already. It's not unique, it's just a reworking of something that's already there. Comte's technocentric philosophy of history is also important. The relationship between humanity and nature can organize the immense variety of world history into a coherent theme. I think that there's a big

future in that idea, that technocentric interpretation of history, if we leave out the Eurocentrism and racism that's characteristic of Comte's more reactionary tendencies. In this respect, comparison with William McNeill is worthwhile: a hard-headed naturalistic approach, arguably positivistic.

Another problem he addresses without solving is positivist moral and political theory, often the Achilles heel of such approaches. Empiricists focus on tables and chairs, space and time. Edmund's words in *King Lear* offer an emblem: “Thou, Nature, art my goddess; to thy law / My services are bound.” Positivism becomes a hymn: “Nearer, my physics, to thee.” It's all physics worship. The problem is that if you don't worship yourself, you don't worship humanity, what do you worship? If you don't worship anything, well then what will your normative theory look like? What will your ethical theory look like? It'll be a big vacuum. Isn't that the weakest part of things like the Vienna Circle, something like Schlick's book on the problems of morality from the perspective of a positivist? It's really lame. It convinces no one, it inspires no one, and it's certainly the Achilles heel of all these naturalistic approaches to philosophy. Granted that we don't want, or I don't want anyway, to adopt Comte's religion of humanity, it raises the question of what you do want to adopt. All these hard-shelled 20th century positivists might want to look at that.

As logical positivism encounters difficulties in logic and epistemology, including debates surrounding Gödel's theorem, pragmatism can appear as one response. Scratching the varnish from a pragmatist may reveal a positivist with a broken heart, disappointed in the original project. The criticism offered here is that pragmatism's moral theory remains weak. That restraint can be viewed as a virtue. It can also be viewed as a vacuum; this is the less charitable judgment.

Comte's practical influence also matters. Brazil's national flag carries the positivist motto “Order and Progress.” Right after the abolition of slavery in 1888, positivists were very influential in developing the new Brazil. For better or worse, it is a kind of transition between Catholicism and its universal moral order, and the technocratic scientific element that is becoming more and more influential among all the elites in every kind of government. A final observation is that all technocratic tendencies in modern politics owe something to Comte.

He was right that political decisions are partly technical. A body such as the Federal Reserve relies on specialist economists to decide monetary policy, including interest rates and measures affecting the money supply. Ordinary citizens generally lack the knowledge of all the relevant equations and mechanisms. A vote by someone who does not understand such questions cannot by itself supply the missing expertise. One may have to trust specialists to do their work well. Knowledge has proliferated so much that no individual can know everything required for every informed decision. Positivism in the form of technocracy therefore remains a live option in the twentieth century. The problem is how they will find a normative basis for that.